How to Install Claude on Your Computer

A complete, beginner-friendly guide to every way of getting Claude.

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Part 1 — What “installing Claude” really means

Claude is an AI assistant made by Anthropic. The phrase “install Claude” is a little ambiguous, because Claude is available in several different forms, and the right one depends entirely on what you want to do. This guide walks through each option from the simplest to the most technical, so you can choose with confidence.

The main ways to use Claude

- **In a web browser** — nothing to install at all. You open a website and start typing.
- **As a desktop application** — a native app for Windows or macOS that lives in your taskbar or dock.
- **On a phone or tablet** — a companion app for quick access on the go.
- **As Claude Code** — a command-line tool for developers who want Claude to help with software directly in a terminal.
- **Through the API** — a way for programmers to call Claude from their own software.

If you simply want to ask questions, write, brainstorm or analyze documents, the browser or desktop app is all you need. If you are a developer, the command-line tool or the API will be more interesting. You can use several of these at once with a single account, and your conversations stay in sync where that makes sense.

> Tip: there is no single “Claude installer” that does everything. Decide what you want to accomplish first, then install only the piece that serves that goal.

Part 2 — Before you start: account and requirements

Almost every way of using Claude begins with a free Anthropic account. Setting this up first will save you time later, because each app simply asks you to sign in.

Creating your account

1. Open **claude.ai** in a web browser.
2. Choose to sign up, using an email address or a supported single-sign-on option.
3. Verify your email if prompted, and set a strong, unique password.
4. Consider turning on two-factor authentication for extra security.

General requirements

- A reliable internet connection. Claude runs in the cloud, so even the desktop app needs to be online.
- A modern web browser kept reasonably up to date.
- For the desktop app, a currently supported version of Windows or macOS.
- For Claude Code, a terminal and, for one install method, the Node.js runtime.
- For the API, a little programming experience and a payment method for usage beyond any free allowance.

None of these are demanding. If your computer can browse the modern web comfortably, it can run Claude in at least the browser and desktop forms.

Part 3 — Using Claude in your web browser

This is the fastest route and works the same on Windows, macOS, Linux and Chromebooks. There is literally nothing to download.

1. Open **claude.ai**.
2. Sign in with the account you created.
3. Type your question or paste text into the message box and press enter.
4. Start a new conversation whenever you change topics, so the context stays focused.

Making the browser version feel like an app

Most browsers can “install” a website as a lightweight app, sometimes called a Progressive Web App. This gives you an icon and a standalone window without a separate download.

- In Chrome or Edge, look for an install icon in the address bar, or open the menu and choose to install or create a shortcut.
- The result opens in its own window and behaves much like a native program.
- This is a good middle ground if you want quick access but prefer not to install the full desktop app.

Part 4 — The Claude desktop app on Windows

The desktop app gives Claude its own window, a place in the taskbar, and a global keyboard shortcut so you can summon it instantly from anywhere.

Step by step

1. Go to **claude.ai/download** and choose the Windows download.
2. Save the installer file, then double-click it to run.
3. If Windows shows a security prompt, confirm that you want to proceed, since you downloaded the file from the official site.
4. Follow the on-screen steps; the installer copies the program and creates shortcuts.
5. Launch Claude from the Start menu and sign in with your account.

After installing

- Pin Claude to the taskbar for one-click access.
- Note the global shortcut so you can open Claude without switching windows.
- Allow the app to start with Windows if you want it always at hand, or disable that in settings if you prefer.

Part 5 — The Claude desktop app on macOS

The macOS app works the same way conceptually, with the familiar Mac installation flow.

1. Open **claude.ai/download** and choose the macOS download.
2. Open the downloaded disk image (the file ending in .dmg).
3. Drag the Claude icon into your Applications folder.
4. Open Claude from Applications or Launchpad. The first time, confirm you want to open an app downloaded from the internet.
5. Sign in with your account.

Helpful extras

- Keep Claude in the Dock for quick access.
- Grant only the system permissions you are comfortable with; you can always change these later in System Settings.
- Use the global shortcut to bring Claude forward without hunting for the window.

Part 6 — Claude on mobile devices

Although this guide is about computers, many people like to carry the same assistant in their pocket. A companion app keeps conversations available on the move.

- On iPhone or iPad, search the App Store for the official Claude app and install it as usual.
- On Android, search the Google Play Store for the official Claude app.
- Sign in with the same account to keep your experience consistent across devices.
- Always confirm the publisher is Anthropic before installing, to avoid imitation apps.

Part 7 — Installing Claude Code (the command-line tool)

Claude Code is a tool for developers. It runs in a terminal, can read and edit files in a project, run commands, and help you build and debug software. It is the most powerful option for programming work, and also the most technical to set up.

Prerequisites

- A terminal application (Terminal on macOS or Linux; PowerShell or Windows Terminal on Windows).
- For the package-manager method, the **Node.js** runtime, which provides the **npm** command.
- Comfort running a few commands by typing them rather than clicking.

Method A: install with npm

1. Confirm Node.js is present by running **node --version**. If it is missing, install it from the official Node.js website first.
2. Install Claude Code globally: **npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code**.
3. Move into a project folder and run **claude** to start.
4. The first run will guide you through signing in to your account.

Method B: native installer

Anthropic also provides a native install command that does not require Node.js. Because the exact command can change, the safest approach is to copy it from the official Claude Code documentation rather than from memory.

Editor and IDE integration

- There are official extensions for **Visual Studio Code** and for **JetBrains** IDEs.
- Install the extension from the editor’s marketplace, then sign in.
- This lets you use Claude’s help without leaving your editor.

First run and everyday use

- Open a terminal inside the project you want help with, then type **claude**.
- Describe your task in plain language; Claude can read files, propose edits and run commands with your approval.
- Keep an eye on what it changes, and use version control so you can review and undo easily.

Part 8 — Using the Claude API for your own projects

If you are building an application that should talk to Claude, you use the API. This is not an install in the usual sense; instead you obtain a key and call Claude from your code.

1. Sign in to the Anthropic Console at **console.anthropic.com**.
2. Create an API key and copy it somewhere safe.
3. Install a software development kit for your language, for example **pip install anthropic** for Python or the equivalent package for JavaScript and TypeScript.
4. Write a small program that sends a message and prints the reply, to confirm everything works.

Good habits with the API

- Never paste your API key into source code that you share or commit to a repository. Store it in an environment variable or a secrets manager.
- Watch your usage; API calls are billed, so set spending limits where available.
- Explore the documentation for features such as tool use and the Model Context Protocol, which let Claude connect to your own data and tools.

Part 9 — Troubleshooting common problems

The installer will not open

Make sure the download finished completely, and that you fetched it from the official site. On Windows, right-click and choose to run it; on macOS, confirm the security prompt for apps downloaded from the internet.

I cannot sign in

Check your internet connection, confirm your email and password, and try resetting your password if needed. If your organization manages your account, you may need to use a specific sign-in option.

The “claude” command is not found

This usually means the install location is not on your system path, or the install did not complete. Reopen your terminal, confirm Node.js and npm are installed for the npm method, and try the install command again.

It feels slow or unresponsive

Because Claude runs in the cloud, performance depends on your connection. Try a wired or stronger network, close unused tabs, and make sure the app is up to date.

Part 10 — Security and privacy best practices

- Download apps only from official sources to avoid tampered or fake versions.
- Use a strong, unique password and enable two-factor authentication.
- Be thoughtful about the sensitive information you share, and review the settings that control how your data is used.
- Keep your operating system and the Claude apps updated so you receive security fixes.
- For developers, treat API keys like passwords and rotate them if they may have leaked.

Part 11 — Updating and uninstalling

Updating

- The web version is always current; there is nothing to do.
- The desktop apps typically update themselves, or prompt you when a new version is ready.
- For Claude Code installed with npm, update by running the install command again, which fetches the latest version.

Uninstalling

- On Windows, remove the desktop app through Settings and the list of installed apps.
- On macOS, drag the app from Applications to the Trash.
- For the npm version of Claude Code, run **npm uninstall -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code**.

Part 12 — Frequently asked questions

Do I need to pay to install Claude?

Creating an account and using the basic web and desktop experiences is free. Some advanced features and heavy API usage are paid.

Can I use Claude offline?

No. Claude runs in the cloud, so an internet connection is required even for the desktop app.

Is there a Linux desktop app?

Linux users can always use the browser version and install it as a web app. Developers on Linux can use Claude Code in the terminal.

Which option should a beginner choose?

Start with the browser at claude.ai. If you like it and want a dedicated window, add the desktop app. Leave the command-line tool and API for when you have a programming need.

Part 13 — Glossary of terms

- **Anthropic** — the company that makes Claude.
- **Claude Code** — the command-line tool that brings Claude into a developer's terminal.
- **API** — a way for software to talk to Claude programmatically.
- **SDK** — a software development kit; a ready-made library for calling the API in a given language.
- **npm** — the package manager that comes with Node.js, used to install command-line tools.
- **Progressive Web App** — a website installed to behave like a standalone application.
- **Two-factor authentication** — a second verification step that strengthens account security.